explained the concept of the ‘pivot’ (or ‘rebalance’) to Asia, then-Secretary of State Hillary Clinton stated clearly that ‘India’s greater role on the world stage will enhance peace and security’. [38] It was during this period that India and the United States began an initial dialogue on East Asia. By the end of Obama’s tenure, India and the United States agreed to a wide-ranging Joint Strategic Vision for the Asia-Pacific and Indian Ocean Region—which provided a strategic underpinning to the relationship—and India was elevated to a Major Defense Partner to enable defence cooperation on India’s terms. [39] The Trump administration reinforced these commitments in bilateral statements with India and in its Free and Open Indo–Pacific Strategy unveiled over its first two years in office. With the conclusion of a host of foundational agreements between the United States and India to enable interoperability, the Biden administration built further on these efforts through a series of Quad working groups (including on maritime issues), elevated bilateral US–India defence and technology dialogues, greater defence industrial cooperation, more military liaisons, and operational cooperation, including as part of the Combined Maritime Forces (CMF).

Throughout this period, cooperation on information sharing—from intelligence to maritime domain awareness—has increased. India has benefited from US platforms including heavy lift, tactical transport and maritime reconnaissance aircraft, as well as helicopters, artillery, and drones. This equipment has facilitated India’s ability to operate farther at sea, including in counter-piracy operations. In terms of interoperability, the two countries now conduct regular exercises involving all three military services. The Malabar exercises involving the navies is most evolved, and now includes Japan and Australia, with exercises alternating between the Indian and Pacific Oceans. The Indian and US armies take part in Yudh Abhyas and Vajra Prahar, involving special operations forces. The air forces conduct Cope India, with the Indian Air Force periodically participating in the United States’ premier Red Flag exercises. A tri-service exercise called Tiger Triumph was also initiated. Despite a progressively deeper partnership in all these areas, efforts at facilitating defence technology